



A PRACTICAL GUIDE FOR PARENTS, TEACHERS & CAREGIVERS

Protecting Young People from Online Radicalisation and Extremist Influence

*Understanding, Recognising and Responding to Online Extremism — A Sri Lankan Handbook for
Families and Schools*

A Child Online Safety & Digital Literacy Resource
For Parents, Teachers, Guardians and Caregivers of Children and Teenagers in Sri Lanka

International Foundation for Digital Child

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Introduction: Why This Guide Matters

This handbook is written for the adults who shape a young person's world: parents and guardians at home, teachers and school counsellors in the classroom, and other caregivers — grandparents, aunts and uncles, youth leaders, and mentors. Whatever your role, the young people in your care benefit when the trusted adults around them understand these risks and speak the same language about them.

Sri Lanka is a young, connected, and rapidly digitising country. Most teenagers today spend several hours a day on smartphones — chatting on WhatsApp, watching YouTube and TikTok, gaming with friends, and exploring communities that have nothing to do with their school, neighbourhood, or family. This is normal, and it is not something to fear.

But the same platforms that connect young people to friends, hobbies, and learning also connect them — often without any warning — to people and content designed to manipulate how they think, who they trust, and how they see the world. This process is called online radicalisation, and it does not only mean recruitment into terrorism. It includes hate speech, extreme nationalism, religious intolerance, conspiracy movements, misinformation, and content that glorifies violence or encourages hostility toward other communities.

Sri Lanka's own history — including the 2019 Easter Sunday attacks, past cycles of ethnic and religious tension, and repeated episodes of online misinformation during moments of national stress — shows that our young people are not immune to these influences. At the same time, Sri Lanka is a country of remarkable diversity: Sinhala, Tamil, Muslim, Burgher and other communities; Buddhist, Hindu, Christian, Islamic and other faiths, sharing one island. This diversity is a strength, and protecting it starts at home.

A Note Before You Begin

This guide does not blame any religion, ethnicity, or political group. Radicalisation is a process that can pull in a young person of any background, through any belief system, using very similar psychological tactics. Our focus throughout is on behaviours, manipulation techniques, and what parents, teachers and caregivers can do — not on labelling any community as dangerous.

You do not need to be a technology expert to protect a child. You need curiosity, patience, and a willingness to stay engaged in a young person's digital life the same way you stay engaged in their school life, friendships, and health. This guide will show you how.

1. What Is Online Radicalisation?

Online radicalisation is the gradual process by which a person's beliefs, attitudes, or emotions are shifted — usually through repeated online exposure — toward extreme, intolerant, or violence-supporting views. It is a process, not a single event. Nobody wakes up radicalised; they are guided there, step by step, often without realising it is happening.

It Is Not Only About Terrorism

When people hear the word "radicalisation," they often think only of terrorist recruitment. In reality, online radicalisation is a much broader spectrum. A young person can be pulled toward any of the following, and these categories frequently overlap:

- Hate speech — content that dehumanises or insults people based on ethnicity, religion, caste, gender, or sexuality.
- Extremist nationalism — the belief that one's own ethnic or national group is superior and under threat from others, justifying hostility or exclusion.
- Religious intolerance — the idea that only one faith (or one interpretation of a faith) is valid, and that other beliefs are a threat to be opposed.
- Conspiracy movements — belief systems built on the idea that hidden, malicious forces secretly control events, media, or governments.
- Misinformation and disinformation — false or misleading claims spread to provoke fear, anger, or division, especially during sensitive national events.
- Glorification of violence — content that presents violent acts, attackers, or armed groups as heroic, justified, or exciting.
- Incitement against communities — content that frames a specific ethnic, religious, or social group as an enemy to be feared, blamed, or confronted.

Why This Matters for Every Sri Lankan Family

Radicalisation is not something that happens to "other people's children." It can affect a bright student, a quiet child, a popular teenager, or a struggling one. It can happen in Colombo or in a rural village, in an international school or a government school, to a Sinhala Buddhist boy, a Tamil Hindu girl, a Muslim teenager, or a Christian youth. The ideology differs from case to case, but the psychological process is remarkably similar everywhere in the world.

Key Idea

Radicalisation is not about what a young person believes at any one moment — it is about the direction they are being pulled, how fast, and by whom. It is not the job of a parent, teacher, or caregiver to police every opinion a teenager holds, but to notice the pull toward hatred, fear, secrecy, and isolation.

2. Who Becomes Vulnerable — and Why

No young person is "born" vulnerable to extremism. Vulnerability comes from unmet emotional needs, and extremist content is deliberately designed to appear to meet those needs better than anything else in the young person's life.

How These Needs Are Exploited

Vulnerability	How Extremist Content Exploits It
Loneliness or social isolation	Online groups offer instant "friends" who seem to understand and accept the young person unconditionally.
Bullying or exclusion (at school or online)	Extremist communities promise strength, protection, and revenge against those who hurt them.
Identity struggles (ethnic, religious, or personal)	Extremist narratives offer a simple, powerful identity: "You are one of us, and we are right."
Family conflict or feeling misunderstood at home	Recruiters position themselves as the only ones who truly "get" the young person, weakening trust in parents, teachers, and other trusted adults.
Desire for belonging	Groups create tight-knit online communities with shared language, symbols, and rituals.
Desire for purpose or significance	Extremist causes offer a mission — "you can be part of something bigger than yourself."
Desire for recognition or status	Online communities reward loyalty and participation with praise, rank, or attention.
Sense of injustice (real or perceived)	Propaganda channels legitimate anger about unfairness toward a specific enemy and a call to action.
Craving excitement or rebellion (common in adolescence)	Extremist content is framed as daring, forbidden, and thrilling — appealing to teenage risk-seeking.

Insight for Parents, Teachers & Caregivers

Ask yourself: does this child or teenager have at least one offline space — family, friends, sport, religious community, hobby group — where they feel genuinely valued? That single factor is one of the strongest protections against radicalisation.

3. Who Influences Young People Online?

Radicalisation rarely begins with a stranger shouting extremist slogans. It usually begins with someone — or something — that seems friendly, relatable, funny, or trustworthy. Understanding the different types of influencers helps parents, teachers and caregivers recognise risk earlier.

a) Charismatic "Recruiters"

These are individuals — sometimes adults, sometimes slightly older peers — who deliberately seek out young people who seem lonely, angry, or searching for identity. They are patient. They may spend weeks or months simply being kind, funny, and attentive before ever mentioning extreme ideas.

b) Online Influencers and Content Creators

Not all influencers intend harm, but some build large followings around grievance, humour that targets specific communities, or "just asking questions" content that slowly normalises extreme views. Young people often trust influencers more than institutions or the trusted adults in their lives, because influencers feel like peers.

c) Anonymous Accounts and Bot-like Networks

Anonymous meme pages, forum accounts, and coordinated networks post provocative content designed to spread quickly. Because there is no visible "face," young people often don't realise how deliberate and organised this content can be.

d) Online Communities and Group Dynamics

Discord servers, WhatsApp/Telegram groups, gaming clans, and comment-section communities can develop their own culture, in-jokes, and shared enemies. A young person may be drawn in by shared gaming interests long before any political or religious content appears — and by the time it does, they already feel like a loyal member of the group.

The Trust-Building Pattern

Across all these influencer types, a common pattern repeats itself:

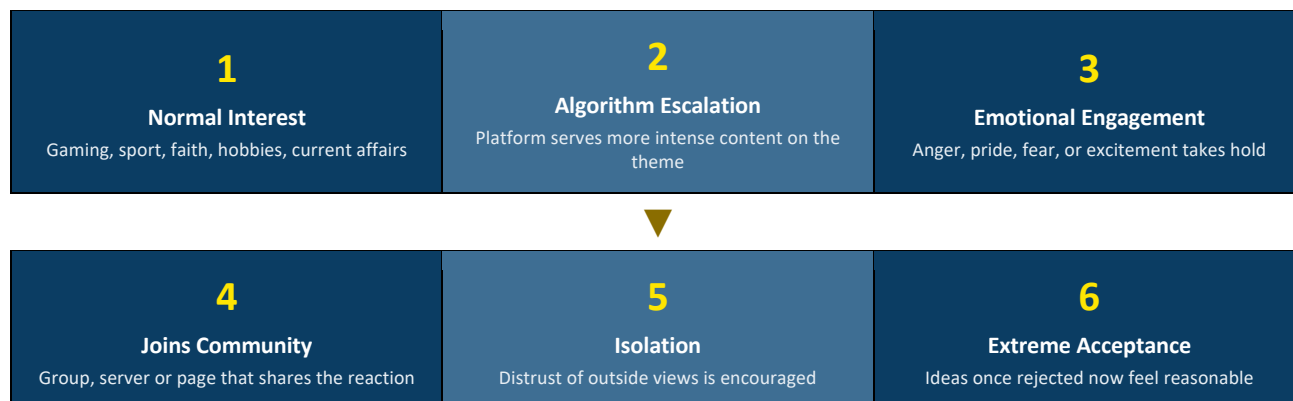
1	2	3	4	5
Friendly Contact	Validation	Private Chat	Grievance	Escalation
Shared interest, humour, gaming, memes	"You're smarter than people give you credit for"	Moves from public group to DMs	"Notice how unfair things are for us?"	Extreme framing, once trust is set

Insight for Parents, Teachers & Caregivers

A trusted adult online is not automatically a threat — most are not. The warning sign is not friendliness itself, but a pattern of moving a child toward secrecy, exclusivity, and "us vs. them" thinking.

4. The Radicalisation Journey

Radicalisation is rarely instant. It typically unfolds as a gradual journey, and understanding each stage helps parents, teachers and caregivers recognise where a young person might currently be — and intervene before the next stage begins.



Why This Model Matters for Caring Adults

This journey can take weeks or over a year. It is rarely obvious from the outside until Stage 4 or 5. This is exactly why early, ongoing conversations about online life (Stages 1–3) are far more effective than trying to "deprogram" a young person after Stage 5 or 6.

5. Manipulation and Persuasion Tactics

Extremist content — regardless of its ideology — tends to reuse the same small set of psychological tactics. Learning to recognise these tactics is one of the most powerful tools a parent, teacher, or caregiver (and a young person) can have.

Tactic	How It Works
Creating belonging	Uses shared symbols, in-group language, nicknames, and "us" framing to make members feel like part of a special family.
Exploiting anger and fear	Highlights real or exaggerated grievances and threats to keep members emotionally activated and less able to think critically.
Creating an enemy	Identifies a specific group — ethnic, religious, political, or ideological — as the source of all problems, giving anger a target.
Spreading misinformation	Uses fabricated statistics, doctored images, or out-of-context videos to "prove" the enemy narrative, especially during sensitive events.
Memes and propaganda	Packages extreme ideas as humour or irony, making them feel harmless, shareable, and "just a joke" — lowering emotional resistance.
"Only we know the truth"	Claims that mainstream media, schools, and government are all lying or complicit, positioning the group as the sole trustworthy source.
Discouraging trust in parents/teachers/society	Frames adults and institutions as out of touch, controlled, or the enemy, isolating the young person from correcting influences.
Gradual escalation	Introduces extreme ideas in small, incremental steps, each one feeling like a logical continuation of the last — never a single dramatic leap.

How to Explain This to a Child or Teenager

You don't need technical language. You can simply say:

"A lot of these pages want you angry, because angry people share more and think less. If a video makes you furious within the first ten seconds, that's worth noticing — not necessarily believing."

6. How Radicalisation Appears on Different Platforms

Each platform has its own culture, and extremist content adapts its style to fit. Sri Lankan parents, teachers and caregivers should understand the specific risks of the platforms their children and students actually use.

YouTube Long "documentaries" build detailed narratives; the sidebar can lead from mainstream to fringe content in a few clicks.	TikTok Short, high-emotion clips spread talking points as jokes or "facts" faster than an adult can review them.
Instagram Meme pages and anonymous "debate" accounts package extremism visually; DMs move chats out of view.	Gaming (Free Fire, PUBG/BGMI, Roblox) Voice chat and linked servers build close bonds; toxic in-jokes can turn into real hostility.
Discord Invite-only inner-circle channels can host escalating content far from parental view.	WhatsApp & Telegram Forwarded messages and channels spread misinformation fast, especially during sensitive national events.

Insight for Parents, Teachers & Caregivers

You do not need to master every platform. You need to know which two or three platforms your own child uses most, and understand the specific risk pattern on each.

7. Warning Signs Parents, Teachers and Caregivers Can Recognise

No single sign proves radicalisation — teenagers change moods and interests constantly as a normal part of growing up. What matters is a pattern of multiple signs appearing together, especially alongside new secrecy or a sudden change in worldview.

Behavioural Changes

- Sudden withdrawal from family activities or long-time friends.
- Spending significantly more time online, especially late at night, in secrecy.
- Becoming defensive, secretive, or angry when asked about online activity.
- Switching off screens quickly or hiding devices when a parent, teacher, or caregiver enters the room.
- New accounts, usernames, or apps the parent, teacher, or caregiver doesn't recognise.

Language and Attitude Changes

- Using "us vs. them" language about a specific ethnic, religious, or political group.
- Repeating unfamiliar slogans, conspiracy theories, or slurs picked up from unclear sources.
- Expressing that only one source (a channel, page, or person) tells "the real truth."
- Dismissing school, mainstream news, or family members as "brainwashed" or "blind."
- Increased certainty and rigidity — a previously open-minded child becoming unwilling to consider other views.

Online Activity Changes

- Following or engaging with pages that mock, blame, or dehumanise a specific community.
- Sharing or saving violent, hateful, or conspiracy-themed content.
- Joining new, closed, or invite-only groups and being unwilling to discuss them.
- Using new symbols, hand signs, flags, or slogans in profile pictures or bios.

Emotional Changes

- Increased anger, fear, or anxiety about a perceived threat from a specific group.
- A new sense of grievance or victimhood that feels disproportionate to their actual experience.
- Sudden pride or excitement about being part of a "special" or "secret" cause.

Important Balance

Teenagers questioning authority, exploring identity, or having strong opinions is healthy and normal. The concern is not that a young person has opinions — it is when opinions harden into hatred, secrecy replaces openness, and empathy for other groups disappears.

8. Case Studies

The following scenarios are illustrative composites, not real individuals. They are designed to help parents, teachers and caregivers recognise realistic patterns across different contexts. No community, religion, or ethnicity is portrayed as inherently at risk — these dynamics can and do appear across all backgrounds.

CASE STUDY

The Gaming Clan

Ravindu, 15, from Kurunegala, loves playing Free Fire with a squad he met online. The group has its own Discord server where they chat daily. Over time, a slightly older member starts posting memes mocking a specific ethnic group whenever the team loses a match. At first it's "just banter," but Ravindu notices the jokes are becoming more frequent and more hostile, and members who object are mocked as "soft." Ravindu starts repeating some of the jokes at school without fully understanding their weight.

What parents, teachers and caregivers can learn: A trusted gaming community can slowly normalise hostility through humour. Parents and teachers should ask not just "who is this young person playing with?" but "what is the culture of that group — including its jokes?"

CASE STUDY

Political Content During Election Season

Ishara, 17, from Colombo, follows several political meme pages on Instagram during a national election. The pages mix genuine satire with increasingly exaggerated claims about opposing candidates and their supporters. Ishara begins to describe supporters of a rival party as "the enemy" and grows frustrated when her parents suggest the claims might not all be accurate.

What parents, teachers and caregivers can learn: Political engagement in teenagers is healthy, but unverified, emotionally charged meme content can distort a young person's view of fellow citizens. Encourage checking claims against reliable news sources before sharing or believing them.

CASE STUDY

Religious Identity Discussions Online

Fathima, 16, from Kandy, joins an Islamic study group on Telegram after feeling that her school does not take her faith seriously. Most of the content is genuine religious education, but one channel administrator gradually introduces content suggesting that Muslims who mix with people of other faiths are "weakening" their community, and that mainstream Sri Lankan society is hostile to Islam.

What parents, teachers and caregivers can learn: Seeking religious identity and community is a healthy, normal part of adolescence. The warning sign is not religious interest itself, but content that pushes a young person toward isolation from — or hostility toward — people of other faiths.

CASE STUDY

Ethnic and Nationalist Narratives

Buddhika, 16, from a rural town in the Southern Province, watches a YouTube channel that started as Sri Lankan history content but has moved toward videos claiming that a minority community is "taking over" local businesses and land. The channel presents itself as patriotic and protective of Sinhala Buddhist heritage, and Buddhika begins to view local minority shopkeepers with suspicion.

What parents, teachers and caregivers can learn: Pride in one's culture, language, and heritage is healthy. It becomes a concern when that pride is redefined as requiring suspicion or hostility toward a neighbouring community, especially through content that frames ordinary economic activity as a threat.

CASE STUDY

Conspiracy Theories

Dinuka, 14, from Negombo, starts watching videos claiming that a global secret organisation controls world events, vaccines, and the media. Initially curious, he becomes increasingly convinced these ideas are true because "so many channels say the same thing" — not realising many of these channels copy content from one another. He starts distrusting his teachers and doctors.

What parents, teachers and caregivers can learn: Conspiracy content often feels convincing because of repetition, not evidence. Teaching a young person to ask "who benefits from me believing this?" and "can I verify this from an independent source?" builds lasting resistance.

CASE STUDY

Misinformation During a Sensitive National Event

During a period of community tension following a local incident, 15-year-old Amali receives a forwarded WhatsApp voice note from a family group chat claiming, without evidence, that a specific community was planning coordinated attacks in nearby towns. Frightened, she shares it with her school friend group before her parents can verify whether it is true. It later turns out to be a recycled hoax from a different country.

What parents, teachers and caregivers can learn: During sensitive events, misinformation spreads fastest because fear overrides fact-checking. Families should agree in advance: unverified forwards are not shared further until confirmed by a reliable source, no matter how urgent they feel.

9. How to Talk to a Child or Teenager: Practical Conversation Guidance

How you talk to a child or teenager about online content matters more than how often. A single respectful, curious conversation is worth more than ten lectures. This section gives practical language you can adapt to your own family, classroom, or care setting.

Conversation Starters That Work

"What's something funny or interesting you saw online today?"

"Who are the creators or pages you follow most? What do you like about them?"

"Have you ever seen something online that made you really angry or scared? What was it?"

"Do people in your gaming group or chat ever joke about other communities? What do you think about that?"

"If you ever saw something online that worried you, would you feel okay telling me — even if you thought I might overreact?"

Good Questions to Ask (Not Just Once — Regularly)

- What made you interested in this page/channel/group in the first place?
- Where do you think this information comes from? How would we check if it's true?
- How does this content make you feel — angry, scared, proud, excited?
- Do the people in this group ever talk badly about a specific community or religion?
- Would you feel comfortable showing me this content? Why or why not?

Mistakes to Avoid

Avoid	Do This Instead
Reacting with panic, shouting, or immediate device confiscation	Stay calm. Panic teaches a young person to hide things from you next time, not to open up.
Mocking or dismissing a young person's beliefs as "stupid"	Ask genuine questions about why the idea appeals to them before challenging it.
Banning an app or topic outright without discussion	Set boundaries together, explaining the reasoning, so the young person understands rather than just resents the rule.
Only talking about online safety when something goes wrong	Make online life a normal, regular topic of conversation — like school or friendships.
Trying to "win" the argument in one conversation	Treat it as an ongoing relationship, not a single debate to be won.
Focusing only on rules and monitoring	Balance monitoring with genuine curiosity, warmth, and connection — trust is your strongest tool.

10. If You Are Concerned: A Step-by-Step Response Plan

If you notice several warning signs together, don't panic — but do act, calmly and deliberately. Here is a practical step-by-step plan.

Step 1 — Observe Before Reacting

Take a few days to quietly note specific examples: what content, what language, what behaviour changes. Avoid confronting the young person in anger or based on a single incident.

Step 2 — Choose the Right Moment

Find a calm, private, unhurried time to talk — not in front of siblings, not immediately after an argument, and not late at night when everyone is tired.

Step 3 — Lead with Curiosity, Not Accusation

Start with open questions rather than statements. For example, instead of "You've become a racist," try "I've noticed you've been talking about [topic] a lot lately — can you tell me more about what you've been watching?"

Step 4 — Listen Fully Before Responding

Let the young person explain their view completely, even if it is uncomfortable to hear. Understanding what emotional need the content is meeting (belonging, anger, purpose) will guide your next steps far better than shutting the conversation down.

Step 5 — Gently Challenge, Don't Shame

Ask questions that encourage critical thinking: "How do we know this is true?" "Have you seen other perspectives on this?" "Who benefits from you believing this?" Avoid ridicule, which pushes young people further into defensive, closed communities.

Step 6 — Strengthen Offline Connection

Increase quality time, shared activities, and involvement in positive offline communities (family, sport, faith community, hobbies). Isolation is often the fuel of radicalisation; connection is the antidote.

Step 7 — Seek Support When Needed

If you feel out of your depth, or if you discover content involving planning of violence, joining an organised extremist group, or serious threats, seek help promptly:

- Talk to the school counsellor, a trusted teacher, or another staff member the young person respects.
- Consult a child psychologist or family counsellor for guidance on communication.
- Contact the National Child Protection Authority (NCPA) helpline 1929 for guidance and support.
- For content suggesting imminent risk of violence or harm, contact the Sri Lanka Police Emergency line 119 without delay.
- Report harmful content directly on the platform (YouTube, TikTok, Meta/Instagram, Telegram, Discord all have reporting tools for hate speech, extremism, and violent content).

- Reach out to reputable Sri Lankan child protection and digital safety organisations, such as IFDC, for guidance and support services.

Step 8 — Stay in the Relationship for the Long Term

Disengagement from extreme views is usually gradual, just like radicalisation itself. Your steady, non-judgemental presence — even after difficult conversations — remains the single most powerful protective factor.

If You Are Ever Unsure

You do not have to handle a serious concern alone. Reaching out early to a counsellor, colleague, or support organisation is a sign of good judgement, not failure.

11. Building Long-Term Resilience

The strongest protection against radicalisation isn't restriction — it is resilience. A young person who thinks critically, feels genuinely connected, and has a secure sense of identity is far less susceptible to manipulation, no matter what they encounter online.

Critical Thinking

- Teach the young person to ask: Who made this content, and why? What are they trying to make me feel?
- Practise checking claims together using reliable sources before believing or sharing them.
- Discuss how algorithms work — that platforms show more of whatever keeps you watching, not necessarily what is true or balanced.

Empathy Across Communities

- Expose the young person to positive, real relationships and stories across Sri Lanka's different ethnic and religious communities.
- Discuss shared Sri Lankan history and culture, alongside honest conversations about the country's difficult past, in age-appropriate ways.
- Model respectful curiosity about other beliefs and backgrounds in your own conversations at home.

Respectful Disagreement

- Show the young person, through your own example, that it is possible to disagree strongly with an idea while still respecting the person who holds it.
- Praise the young person when they change their mind based on new information — this reinforces flexible, healthy thinking.

Healthy Friendships and Belonging

- Support offline friendships, clubs, sports teams, and community groups where the young person feels genuinely valued.
- Stay aware of the young person's social world — both online and offline — without being intrusive.

Community Involvement

- Encourage participation in scouting, sports, arts, volunteering, religious youth groups, or school societies that build positive identity and mentorship.
- Positive adult role models outside the family (coaches, mentors, religious teachers) provide additional protective relationships.

Positive Identity Development

- Help the young person build a sense of identity based on their strengths, values, and relationships — not solely on opposition to another group.
- Celebrate the young person's individuality, talents, and achievements regularly, so their sense of worth isn't dependent on validation from risky online communities.

Resilience Checklist for Families and Schools

- ☐ We talk regularly and calmly about what our child sees online — not just when something goes wrong.
- ☐ Our child knows they can show us worrying content without automatic punishment.
- ☐ We know the main apps and platforms our child uses, and roughly how they work.
- ☐ Our child has at least one strong offline community (family, sport, faith, hobby, friends).
- ☐ We model respectful disagreement and curiosity about other beliefs in our own conversations.
- ☐ We have discussed how to verify information before believing or sharing it.
- ☐ We know what to do and who to contact if we become seriously concerned.

Sri Lanka Quick-Reference: Help and Reporting

Keep this page handy. In an urgent situation, act quickly and calmly.

Need	Contact
Immediate danger / threat of violence	Sri Lanka Police Emergency — 119
Child protection concerns / abuse	National Child Protection Authority (NCPA) Helpline — 1929
Mental health support / counselling	National Mental Health Helpline — 1926, or your family doctor / school counsellor
Reporting extremist or hateful content online	Use the in-app "Report" tool on YouTube, TikTok, Instagram/Meta, Telegram, or Discord
Digital safety guidance for families	IFDC — International Foundation for Digital Child (IFDC)

Closing Note for Parents, Teachers and Caregivers

Raising and educating a child in the digital age is not about eliminating risk — that is not possible, and trying too hard to do so can push young people toward secrecy. It is about building a relationship strong enough that a young person wants to bring their questions, their doubts, and even their mistakes, to you.

Sri Lanka's future depends on a generation of young people who can think critically, empathise across communities, and resist the pull of hatred and division — online and offline. As a parent, teacher, or caregiver, you are one of the most powerful influences in making that possible.

Remember

You don't need to be perfect. You need to stay curious, stay calm, and stay close.